

3.1 Rationale

Ensuring a broad, comparable and coherent course of study

Our specification is designed to ensure a broad, comparable and coherent student experience, with each paper constructed around distinct principles which are carried through to assessment.

Breadth

The specification ensures a substantial study of history as its structure embeds the requirement to study history across three eras, three time scales and three geographical contexts and incorporates each of the five specified elements. Breadth is thereby assured.

Comparability

Our assessments are broken into two papers:

- Paper 1: Understanding the modern world
- Paper 2: Shaping the nation

Paper 1: Understanding the modern world helps students to understand key developments and events in modern world history.

Paper 2: Shaping the nation enables students to understand key developments and events in the history of Britain.

The specification offers choice of content and flexible pathways to allow teachers to design a curriculum that is relevant to students, engages them and stimulates their interest in history, whilst maintaining high levels of comparability.

Comparability is achieved through common design principles for the content of options within each element together with consistent approaches to assessment of options within each element.

Coherence

The specification supports the achievement of the subject aims and outcomes as outlined within the GCSE subject content defined by the Department of Education (DfE). It allows the construction of a KS4 curriculum that not only has integrity in its own right, but also sits within a coherent curriculum linking Key Stage 3 to AS and A-level.

Both papers are equally weighted, ensuring that students receive a balanced and coherent course of study which enables them to develop and extend their knowledge and understanding of specified key events, periods and societies in both a British and wider world context, exposing them to the wide diversity of human experience.

Each paper is divided into two sections.

Paper 1: Understanding the modern world

- Section A: Period studies
- Section B: Wider world depth studies

Paper 2: Shaping the nation

- Section A: Thematic studies
- Section B: British depth studies with the historic environment

Each section is worth 25% of the overall course of study, equating to approximately 30 hours teaching time per section, ensuring that the elements are reasonably balanced.

There are a variety of ways in which the specification gives teachers the opportunity to make a coherent course of study which engages and enriches students' experience of studying history.

Regardless of options studied, students will develop a secure understanding of chronology, knowledge and understanding of history on different scales and contexts, apply historical concepts and processes and engage with the nature of evidence and interpretation. In each pathway, students will engage with a variety of perspectives, such as political, social and economic, and investigate the contributions of key individuals and groups. In this way students will be able to draw parallels and make links between the distinct areas of study.

Each element is based around design principles which encourage students, through assessment, to develop the same skills assigned to each element and they will broaden and deepen their historical knowledge. One design principle is that each paper tests the full range of assessment objectives. Another design principle is that both sections of both papers target three different assessment objectives. In this way a balanced approach to knowledge and skills acquisition throughout the course of study is promoted.

The prescribed elements can be taught in any order, allowing the specification to be delivered in a way that enables a school to put it into operation effectively and maximise the potential for continuity and coherence with KS3 and progression to A-level.

While the prescribed elements can be taught in any order, one way teachers can achieve coherence would be to teach the British content together and then follow with the modern world content or teach the modern world first and then British. Alternatively, teachers may wish to follow on from their Key Stage 3 curriculum.

A possible course of study for the British content which would promote understanding of chronology and help put key events and developments in a wider perspective would be to start teaching the thematic unit and then pause at the right chronological moment to focus on the depth study (understanding the historic environment) and then return to the thematic study.

The modern world content can be taught in any order. It may follow directly on from the Key Stage 3 curriculum. Teachers could choose to focus on the domestic history of one country and then teach one of the conflict and tension options or in the reverse order depending on what is most suitable for their students and department.